

T-storm 95/78 • Tomorrow: T-storm 90/75 B20

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, JULY 17, 2025 • \$4

Accounts paint grim picture of Fla. facility

Reports of limited water, relentless mosquitoes at migrant detention center

BY LORI ROZSA, DAVID OVALLE AND RACHEL HATZIPANAGOS

Two weeks after it opened, a temporary migrant detention center in the Everglades is facing expensive logistical challenges: portable toilets routinely back up, sewage needs to be collected and trucked out, and swarms of mosquitoes attack detainees and staff alike.

Without permanent structures, electricity or running water, drinking and bathing water has to be brought in several times a day but is still in short supply, and rainwater leaks into the tents that protect detainees' chain-link cells, according to interviews with three former guards and phone interviews with detainees.

Their accounts offer details of conditions inside the \$450 million detention center, which has become a symbol for the Trump administration's aggressive immigration enforcement policies and been dubbed "Alligator Alcatraz" by Republicans. Five other states are considering using the site as a model, said Homeland Security Secretary Kristi L. Noem, as Immigration and Customs Enforcement prepares to double the nation's

SEE DETENTION CENTER ON A14

Decision delayed: Kilmar Abrego García, if freed, faces expulsion. **A2**

'Third-country' deportations: U.S. sends 5 men to Eswatini. **A9**



KENT NISHIMURA/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

President Donald Trump said the ouster of Federal Reserve Chair Jerome H. Powell is "highly unlikely — unless he has to leave for fraud."

White House push for voter data roils local offices

BY PATRICK MARLEY AND YVONNE WINGETT SANCHEZ

The Trump administration and its allies have launched a multipronged effort to gather data on voters and inspect voting equipment, sparking concern among local and state election officials about federal interference ahead of the 2026 midterms.

The most unusual activity is happening in Colorado — a state that then-candidate Donald Trump lost by 11 points — where a well-connected consultant who says he is working with the

White House is asking county clerks whether they will allow the federal government or a third party to physically examine their election equipment. Federal agencies have long offered technical assistance and cybersecurity advice to election officials but have not examined their equipment because election laws tightly limit who has access.

Separately, the Justice Department has taken the unusual step of asking at least nine states for copies of their voter rolls, and at least two have turned them over, according to state officials.

In addition, two DOJ lawyers have asked states to share information about voters to implement a Trump executive order that would shift some power over elections from the states to Washington. Courts have temporarily blocked key provisions of that order, including changing mail ballot deadlines and requiring voters to provide proof of citizenship. The DOJ attorneys have asked to talk about a different provision, which has not been halted by the courts, focused on sharing information.

The administration's efforts,

fueled by Trump's false claims that the 2020 election was stolen, have rattled state and local election officials from both parties who have spent years contending with threats, harassment and litigation. Under the Constitution, states are responsible for running elections, and the federal government plays a limited role — such as by dictating when states must offer opportunities to register to vote — that

SEE ELECTIONS ON A5

Voting Rights Act: Kavanaugh pauses ruling on who may sue. **A3**

Order halting some studies overrode NIH career staff

BY HANNAH NATANSON, CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON AND JOEL ACHENBACH

In May, President Donald Trump signed an executive order in the Oval Office surrounded by his top health officials, vowing a crackdown on "dangerous gain-of-function research" on viruses and pathogens that he alleged was occurring in the United States with inadequate oversight. "It's a big deal," Trump had said, alluding to the highly contested theory that the covid pandemic was caused by a lab leak related to such research in China.

Soon after, researchers at the National Institutes of Health spent weeks assessing experiments for risk and preparing a report for the White House on what studies to halt, according to internal emails obtained by The Washington Post and interviews with two career staffers familiar with the process.

But after the director of the NIH's infectious-disease institute signed off on the findings, the politically appointed No. 2 in command at the NIH, Matthew Memoli, overrode career staff, according to the emails and staffers, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to discuss internal deliberations.

SEE NIH ON A6

Grim outlook: An effort to predict extreme rainfall is put on hold. **A3**



SALWAN GEORGES/THE WASHINGTON POST

Syria's Defense Ministry in Damascus was the target of repeated Israeli airstrikes on Wednesday.

Israeli strikes stoke Syrian conflict

BY SALWAN GEORGES, KAREEM FAHIM, MOHAMAD EL CHAMAA AND ABBIE CHEESEMAN

DAMASCUS, SYRIA — Israel on Wednesday launched what it said were "dozens" of strikes across Syria, including in the capital, escalating a conflict with a fledgling government that was already grappling with domestic unrest in which scores of people have been killed.

Israel tied Wednesday's strikes and others this week to that internal conflict, saying it was attacking forces of the new Islamist government to protect the

Aggression comes as new government tries to quell sectarian violence

Druze minority.

The Trump administration, which has pursued warmer relations with Syria following the toppling last year of dictator Bashar al-Assad, including by easing sanctions, said it was trying to calm tensions. Secretary of State Marco Rubio, speaking at the White House on Wednesday, blamed the violence on a "misun-

derstanding" between Israel and Syria stemming from the sectarian conflict in Syria's south.

"We've been engaged with them all morning long and all night long, with both sides," he said. "We think we're on our way towards real de-escalation," he said.

Israeli Defense Minister Israel Katz said the Israel Defense Forces would "continue to operate forcefully in Sweida to destroy the forces that attacked the Druze until their full withdrawal."

SEE SYRIA ON A12

Gaza crisis: A stampede at an aid center killed over 20 people. **A12**

Inside the Silicon Valley quest to breed super-babies

Genetic firms foresee a 'blessed' generation that will avoid disease. Many scientists are skeptical.

BY ELIZABETH DWOSKIN AND YEGANEH TORBATI

A group of well-heeled, 30-something women sat down to dinner last spring at a table set with pregnancy-friendly mocktails and orchids, ready to hear a talk about how to optimize their offspring.

Noor Siddiqui, the founder of an embryo-screening start-up and the guest of honor at the backyard event in Austin, offered a grand vision of custom-built algorithms and genome analysis that would help eradicate illness and disease. Shivon Zilis, a tech executive who had just given birth to Elon Musk's then-secret 13th child, and other guests donned pastel-colored baseball hats Siddiqui handed out. They were emblazoned with a single word: BABIES.

Siddiqui is a rising star in the realm of fertility start-ups backed by tech investors. Her company, San Francisco-based Orchid Health, screens embryos for thousands of potential future illnesses, letting prospective parents plan their families with far more information about their progeny than ever before. For now, her approach has been taken up mostly in her moneyed social circle. But one day, maybe not far off, it could change the way many babies are made everywhere — posing new moral and political questions as reproduction could increasingly become an outcome not of sex but of genetic preselection and data-mining.

"For something as consequential as your child, I don't think people want to roll the dice," the 30-year-old entrepreneur told

SEE BABIES ON A4

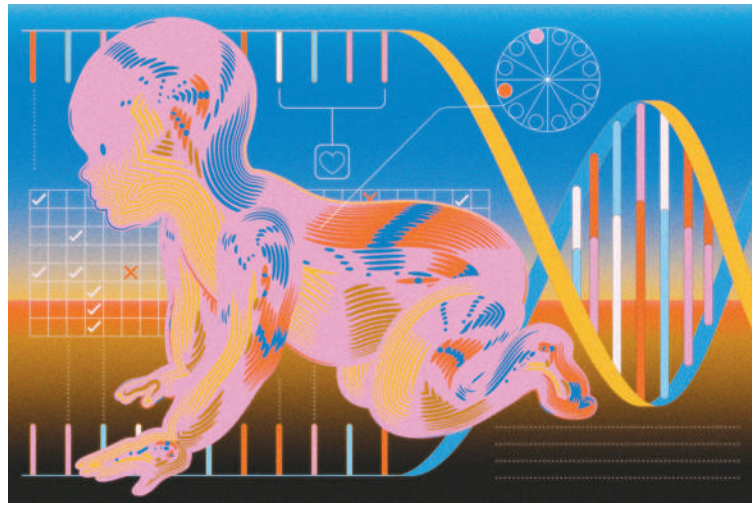


ILLUSTRATION BY PETRA PETERFFY/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

IN THE NEWS

Early detection A big medical trial will study the effectiveness of new blood tests designed to find cancer long before symptoms arise. **A6**

Trayon White Sr. The ousted D.C. Council member is set to face colleagues who called him unfit for the job after he won an election that returns him to the Ward 8 seat. **B13**

THE NATION The president attacked Republicans questioning the handling of the Epstein case. **A3**
On the banks of the Guadalupe River, Texans navigate the flood's devastating losses. **A7**

THE WORLD In Kyiv, nighttime strikes in recent months have made sleep fitful, if not impossible. **A10**
Iceland's Sundhnukur volcano dazzlingly erupted for the 12th time in four years. **A11**

THE ECONOMY As Silicon Valley embraces AI, Meta is recruiting the industry's "superathletes" — who can earn \$100 million bonuses. **A13**

THE CLIMATE In the hot Southwest, swamp coolers are yielding to pricier air-conditioning units. **A15**

STYLE Two Fox reporters recently got engaged to congressmen. But how do you balance love and objectivity? **B1**

SPORTS The Commanders are expected to add eight-time Pro Bowl linebacker Von Miller to boost their defense. **B7**

THE REGION As fundraising lags, Lt. Gov. Winsome Earle-Sears (R) is shaking up her campaign in the Virginia governor's race. **B13**

LOCAL LIVING "Birdnesting," where kids stay home and divorced parents shuttle back and forth, can work in the right situation.

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